

31 Jul 2026

Prime Minister Lawrence Wong

Dear Sir,

I write as a concerned citizen who attended last night's dialogue session at Telok Blangah Community Club about the Gillman Barracks redevelopment proposal.

Whilst there was general appreciation of MP Rachel Ong's initiative to organise the session, there were many who questioned the conspicuous absence of Minister Grace Fu, who heads the Ministry of Sustainability and Environment. In response to community demand, MP Ong had put in an advance request for Minister Grace Fu to attend the session, yet the event moderators and government representatives were silent on why the Minister had seen fit not to attend. Her absence, and the apparent lack of leadership by MSE in this redevelopment proposal, was seen as an example of silo government. I daresay it was also seen as a tacit admission that the planned deforestation is wholly indefensible from the perspective of an environmental stakeholder.

The dialogue session lasted for more than 3 hours past 11pm, and I observed that the objections to the redevelopment were unanimous across all demographic profiles. These objections stemmed from the apparent pursuit of housing KPIs without a holistic consideration of true environmental, heritage, cultural, climate and community costs of deforestation.

A detailed summary of the questions asked at the meeting has been shared with MP Ong by a fellow citizen. A copy is attached. Most respectfully, I ask that you review it alongside any other report that may have been submitted to you by the agencies, as this will provide a more complete, 360^o understanding of how strongly the community feels about the long-term, highly negative impact of the redevelopment plan.

Chief amongst the residents' voiced concerns:

- (a) That URA and HDB are going to push through their plans no matter what, and that the community will have no say at all in the redevelopment plan. This was gathered from the public announcements made by these agencies in Jul 2026 re the building of flats on the affected land, as well as notices given to the residents along Preston Road to vacate their premises by end-Dec 2027.
- (b) The above concern was further driven by the fact that even though the Environmental Impact Assessment ("EIA") and Heritage Impact Assessment

("HIA") reports included findings of potential damage to flora and fauna (including endangered species, heritage trees and a forest stream) and loss of heritage buildings, URA and HDB elected to continue with the public announcement of the redevelopment plan as if the final decision had already been made.

- (c) Residents were highly vocal about the urban heat impact of the planned deforestation. The consensus was that, if our mature forest is turned into a concrete jungle, we will lose the massive cooling effect of the forest canopy which cannot be replaced by just the planting of a few roadside trees. Much was said about how the plan was in stark contrast to the government's "One Million Trees" movement to create a "City in Nature" for the sake of climate resilience and protection of bio-diversity, not to mention Singapore's recent signing of a treaty to fight against deforestation (the Glasgow Leaders' Declaration on Forests and Land Use). It was observed by multiple residents that the EIA was completely remiss in omitting a study on the urban heat impact of deforestation coupled with the proposed build of high-density housing. One irate elderly gentleman spoke passionately about how he had moved from Tampines to Telok Blangah to escape the concrete-jungle heat at Tampines, and implored the government "not to turn this into another Tampines".
- (d) ***Notably, in the maximum capacity gathering of 350+ residents that stretched past 11pm, with >3 hours for everyone to have a chance of speaking, not one single person spoke in support of the proposed redevelopment.*** Whilst one resident shared his previous difficulty in getting a BTO flat, even he and his wife were advocates to keep the forest intact. To be clear, a number of the residents did express their understanding that there is a need for public housing; the objections were more along the lines of "Why Gilman Barracks? Why build on mature forest land? Surely there are other more suitable construction sites."
- (e) The government agencies did not appear fully open to the need to adapt their well-oiled machinery for town-planning and building construction to take into account the present-day climate reality that calls for a more integrated approach to valuing and protecting our remaining forest land. Many residents spoke of the need for the Ministry of Sustainability and Environment to play a more muscular role in the currently proposed redevelopment, as well as all future land use plans. In short, the government agencies need to be pro-active in forest protection from the start, and not tag on an EIA report as a mere formality to be conducted towards the end of the process, with no obligation for building plans to be halted or substantially changed by the contents of the EIA report.

- (f) There was a palpable lack of community trust regarding HDB/URA's stated commitment that the proposed construction will deploy mitigation measures to protect the small sliver of forest that would be spared, including the preservation of the forest stream within Gillman Forest. A resident spoke of her utter disappointment with HDB/URA regarding the recent redevelopment at the site of the former Keppel golf club. Promises had been made to the community that efforts would be made to protect the mature greenery in that area, and to protect the mangrove swamp at Berlayer Creek. These turned out to be empty promises, as the construction crew retained only one mature tree and two coconut trees, seemingly for the purpose of providing limited shade to the construction workers, rather than for environmental protection. We were told how the natural waterways were replaced by concrete waterways, and the construction silt/debris damage to Berlayer Creek was so great that it has already killed the mangrove trees and destroyed the otter habitat. This begged the question of how the promise of any future mitigation measures at Gillman Barracks will be enforced, or whether they will be enforced at all.
- (g) The residents expressed hope that going forward, the government agencies will evolve towards a truer, less siloed commitment for building a "City in Nature" when making decisions on land use. Several questions were posed as to whether there is any inter-agency consideration of a long-term, aggregate goal in preserving a target % of our forest land, versus the status quo where individual, smaller parcels of forest land are assessed separately, with no holistic consideration for generational loss of forest. In hearing these concerns, I could not help but think that if we extrapolate the current practice to its logical conclusion, we will end up having cut down all secondary forest until only the central catchment area is left. Is that truly a legacy that we want to pass down to our future generations? A concrete jungle island-wide, with 6-10 million people converging on weekends at Bukit Timah forest for the only forest respite left on the island?

Respectfully, I ask that the above concerns be raised at Parliament so that our elected representatives can truly appreciate the strength of the public opposition to the proposed Gillman Barracks redevelopment.

Sincerely,



Kareen Looi